CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

MOBILE APP DEVELOPER IN THE AI ERA

The phone is where the customers are — and cross-platform tools mean one developer can now ship to all of them.

★ TL;DR — Median around $125K, fully remote, in a 6–12 month band if you focus on one stack. The catch: app stores are winner-take-most — your money is in employed product work, not indie lottery tickets. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

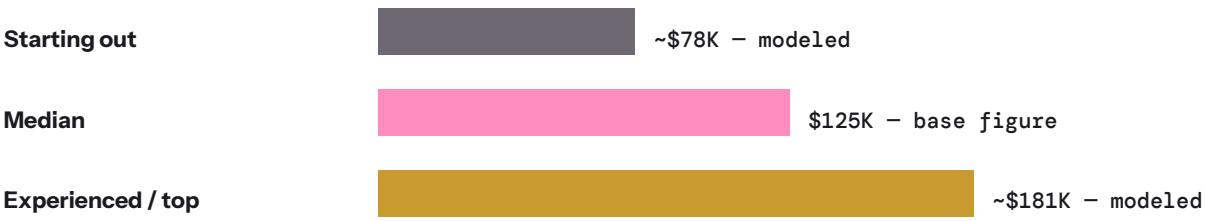
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$125K · TRAINING 4+ years · AI RISK MEDIUM

- One codebase now covers iOS and Android (React Native, Flutter) — that's the employable version of this job.
- Portfolios here are brutally concrete: apps in the store, or it didn't happen.
- AI writes screens and boilerplate; architecture, performance and platform quirks stay human.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Mobile App Developer is a ~$125K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A MOBILE APP DEVELOPER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Build app screens and the logic behind them in a framework like React Native or Flutter
- ✓ Connect apps to APIs, payments, notifications and analytics
- ✓ Debug across a zoo of devices, OS versions and screen sizes
- ✓ Ship updates through app store review — and fix what review rejects

Think: a builder of tiny shops that live in people's pockets — every square centimeter is rent you pay in attention.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
AI generates UI code, standard screens, data-layer boilerplate and unit tests. The 'build me a settings page' class of work is automated.	App architecture, offline behavior, battery and performance judgment, and the last-mile platform quirks that only appear on real devices. Product sense stays human.

⚠ **Native-only purists and framework tourists both lose — employers hire for the stack their product already uses. Research your target companies' stacks before choosing.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ High pay and fully remote roles ✓ Your work lives on real phones, used by real people ✓ Freelance and product paths both work	✗ App store review roulette on deadline day ✗ A device zoo that breaks your beautiful layout weekly ✗ On-call for crashes after every release

Good fit? You're a builder who likes tight constraints, visual feedback and shipping to a store anyone can download.
Bad fit? You hate detail work — mobile is a thousand small platform details wearing a trench coat.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — CROSS-PLATFORM EMPLOYED TRACK	DOOR B — NATIVE SPECIALIST
Learn React Native or Flutter plus the JavaScript/Dart foundations under it, ship two store-ready apps, and apply to product companies. This is where the salaried volume is.	Go deep on one platform (Swift/iOS or Kotlin/Android), often via a formal course or certificate. Fewer postings, deeper moats, and platform teams pay for the depth.

Smart move: Ship one app that does one thing genuinely well and maintain it for six months — updates, crash fixes, reviews answered. Maintenance history is what senior portfolios show and juniors never have.
Where you land after: Senior mobile engineer → mobile lead / staff engineer, or indie products with real distribution skills.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
FOUNDATIONS	FRAMEWORK CORE	FIRST STORE	SECOND APP,	PORTFOLIO LIKE	APPLY TO

STEP 1 — Foundations

FREE–$100 · MONTHS 1–2

- JavaScript/TypeScript (for React Native) or Dart (for Flutter) plus general programming basics.
- Mobile UI concepts: navigation, state, lists, forms.

STEP 2 — Framework core

FREE–$200 · MONTHS 2–4

- Build guided projects, then rebuild one without the tutorial.
- Add a certificate course if you want a credential line — optional in this field, apps matter more.

STEP 3 — First store app

MONTHS 3–6

- One complete app: auth, API data, local storage, notifications.
- Publish it. Surviving store review once teaches more than a month of tutorials.

STEP 4 — Second app, different flavor

MONTHS 5–8

- Maps, payments, media or chat — pick the feature family you skipped.
- Write tests and set up crash reporting like a professional.

STEP 5 — Portfolio like a product

MONTHS 6–10

- Store listings with real screenshots, changelogs and review replies.
- Case notes on one hard bug and one performance fix.

STEP 6 — Apply to product teams MONTHS 8-12

- Target companies whose stack matches yours; check their job posts before applying elsewhere.
- Live-coding rounds test framework fluency — drill the common patterns.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: pick the stack (one only) and get a hello-world app running on a real phone.
- □ Days 1–30: language basics done; first multi-screen app with API data working.
- □ Days 31–60: framework patterns solid; app #1 feature-complete in development.
- □ Days 61–90: app #1 submitted to a store; app #2 scoped and started.
- □ Day 90: one app in a store (or in review) and a second underway — already ahead of most applicants.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **IN THE STORE, OR IT DIDN'T HAPPEN.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.